THE VERSATILE DIRECTOR

"**I DON'T THINK OF MY** gender as a minority," Zoya Akhtar said to huge applause at BUSINESS TODAY's Most Powerful Women Summit and Awards. Which is why Akhtar's women always shine. Take, for instance, *Dahaad*'s policewoman who wouldn't let the caste prejudice she faces hinder her; a pregnant bride in *Made in Heaven* who marries herself after realising her boyfriend isn't ready for it; or the sex worker in *Talaash*. "Feminism for us is very simple: equal rights and equal opportunities," Akhtar told INDIA TODAY magazine earlier this year while talking about her collaboration with filmmaker Reema Kagti. Friends for over two decades now, the duo founded Tiger Baby Films in 2017.

Akhtar avoids putting labels on her filmmaking, but it's hard to overlook how sharply her work captures the experiences of women navigating tricky spaces, whether it is being stuck in an unhappy marriage (*Dil Dhadakne Do*) or in a haunted house (*Ghost Stories*). Her films also express her socio-political worldview firmly.



Zoya Akhtar, *50*
Filmmaker

MANDAR DEODHAR

Even a light-hearted movie like *The Archies* has a track called 'Everything is Politics', based on how youth can't be proud of their ignorance.

Art in Akhtar's world can't be separated from its creator. "How the director treats a scene where the guy is trying to woo the girl, that tells me what he thinks," she says. "You are in everything you do." For her, a creator can't exist in isolation either, and so she keeps her ear to the ground through news and pop culture trends. "It feeds you. Otherwise, you get stuck in a loop," she says.

In her 15-year-long career, Akhtar has directed only five features. But when she does have a release, it usually comes with a bang. She features on the wishlists of a number of actors, including Vicky Kaushal, who recently said on *Koffee with Karan*, "Zoya, my journey has been luck by chance too. *Mera dil bhi dhadakne do* (let my heart beat too)."

Her popularity, though, isn't merely because of her family's legacy. Akhtar had to build it, brick by brick. For her first film, *Luck By Chance* (2009), she was turned down by six actors before she approached her brother, Farhan. The film didn't do very well at the box office, but what it did do was signal her arrival. With *Gully Boy*, that arrival was finally noticed far and wide.

Akhtar's creative process is not simple, but if there's one thing she looks for in every project, she says it's this: "I have to do what I want to do. It has to scare me a little." ■

-Suhani Singh

ACCOMPLISHMENT

2023 saw the release of two series and two features that showcased Akhtar's versatility and ability to stoke conversation

ADVICE TO WOMEN

"Just be nice to people. Acknowledge and validate people. Share the victories"

FOUR-LEGGED FRIENDS

Zoya likes spending early mornings with her two beagles, Boogie and Lucky Luciano